Some scholars have argued that a consequence of the state's plural patronage to temples and mathas, especially through the nayaka governors, was to raise competition between various sects of Hinduism, even as it perhaps fostered a broader Hindu identity.[25]

The language of the Vijayanagar court was Telugu. Kannada and Sanskrit were common too. For writing material, according to Razzaq, people used either coconut fronds or cloth, the latter for more durable records. In his fifties, after his aggressive military campaigns, Krishnadevaraya took greater interest in the literary arts. He wrote *Amuktamalyada*, a book of Telugu verse that relates the love of Andal, a Tamil poetess-saint, for Vishnu and their marriage. He had eight great poets in his court, including Allasani Peddana, 'grandfather of Telugu poetry', and Tenali Ramakrishna (or Tenali Raman), poet, scholar and court jester, who became the hero of many a folk story I read as a child even in north India.

Another celebrated poet in the realm was Atukuri Molla, a woman of the potter caste, who composed her own version of the Ramayana in Telugu verse, recited it in the court of Krishnadevaraya and won praise and honour from the court poets. Not far from the city lived a lower-caste poet-saint and shepherd, Kanaka Dasa, who was denied entry into temples. His songs deftly point out the absurdity of the logic that underpins caste, as in the following verse:

> To what caste does the soul belong?
> To what caste do life and love belong?
> To what caste do the five senses belong?
> If a soul is united with God, the Soul of Souls,
> What does caste have to do with it?[26]

Vijayanagar was a Hindu empire and its elites had many identities distinct from that of Muslim elites in the Deccan. Religion was one pillar of identity for both groups, but many Muslim elites, even after generations in the Deccan, also identified with their Turko-Afghan roots and the then dominant world of Persian language and culture. Notably, Vijayanagar's elites, too, had acquired many Persianate affinities. Even without conversion to Islam or syncretic religious movements, writes Phillip B. Wagoner, a cultural historian of the Deccan, the material and political